PRINCIPLE III: AI-ASSISTED LANGUAGE EDUCATION SHOULD BE PURPOSEFUL

Guideline 5

Enhance theory- and policy-informed language pedagogy

About this guideline

The effective use of artificial intelligence in language education is a function of the quality of uses rather than the quantity of AI tools and AI-supported activities. Quality, in this context, refers to how rich, inclusive and engaging language learning experiences are, and how artificial intelligence improves learning outcomes.

Effective language learning requires opportunities for **meaningful interaction**. This is an area where AI-powered conversational agents might prove helpful, by providing learners with low-stakes spaces for extended communicative practice, particularly in contexts where access to target language speakers is limited (Bibauw et al., 2019; see also Guideline 6). Such interactions can be designed to foreground meaning-making rather than formal accuracy, aligning with communicative and task-based approaches to language teaching (Ellis, 2003; Long, 2015). Additionally, AI can be used to efficiently generate materials for open-ended, contextualised tasks that require learners to negotiate meaning, express personal perspectives and engage in genuine communicative exchange, rather than mechanical practice. Using effective prompting (i.e., clear learning goals, defined outcomes and evaluation criteria; see also Section 2.4), such activities could draw on the learners' interests, experiences and linguistic repertoires, and provide necessary scaffolding to support the implementation of the tasks. Used in this way, artificial intelligence can be deployed to support the development of communicative competence, aligning with contemporary policy frameworks.

Additionally, AI tools can serve as valuable assistants in addressing class heterogeneity by supporting the **differentiation** of learning goals, content and tasks. They enable teachers to tailor materials to individual learners' levels, interests and needs, providing more personalised and inclusive instruction. For instance, speech-to-text functions can assist students who benefit from written transcriptions of spoken language, supporting learners with hearing difficulties or those who process information better visually. Conversely, text-to-speech functions can enhance language learning by introducing more spoken input, aiding pronunciation, listening comprehension and fluency. Teachers can generate multiple sets of exercises from the same input or adapt learning materials to match students' language proficiency levels. Language teachers can enhance language learning by developing multimodal learning supports assisted by AI, such as visuals, graphics, videos, interactive exercises and other multimedia resources.

Just as it has transformed classroom reality, the emergence of AI has radically changed **assessment** in language learning (Kherbouche, 2026). Traditional analogue assessment formats, such as essays and presentations, can no longer be unproblematically regarded as evidence of learning. AI challenges

teachers to rethink evaluation practices, shifting the focus from artefacts of knowledge to the learning process, collaborative learning and the development of communicative competence. While mindful of legal restrictions on high-stakes assessment, teachers can leverage the ability of AI to provide learners with positive and constructive comments for feedback purposes in a number of ways, such as providing students with personalised feedback and feedforward based on transparent assessment criteria, or organising structured peer and group assessment. Furthermore, AI-assisted assessment can help mitigate some cases of unreliability in human assessment, such as teacher fatigue, timing (within the academic calendar or within a day), the examiner's physical or psychological state, the sequence of student submissions and subjective overreactions to certain error types, etc., which have been well documented before the emergence of AI (Fleming, 2007).

References

Bibauw S., François T. and Desmet P. (2019), "Discussing with a computer to practice a foreign language: research synthesis and conceptual framework of dialogue-based CALL", *Computer Assisted Language Learning*, Vol. 32, Issue 8, pp. 827-877, available at: https://doi.org/10.1080/09588221.2018.1535508.

Ellis R. (2003), *Task-based language learning and teaching*, Oxford University Press, Oxford.

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Kherbouche R. (2026), *Évaluer en formation à l'ère de l'IA générative : Manuel pratique pour repenser l'évaluation des apprentissages* [Evaluating in education in the age of generative AI: a practical manual for rethinking evaluation in learning], Chronique sociale, Lyon.

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Competences and reflection questions

5.1 I can use AI in ways that foreground meaning-making and authenticity

Descriptor: *How consistently do my AI-assisted practice opportunities foreground meaning-making and authentic language use?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- When I use conversational agents or AI-generated tasks for communicative practice, am I clear about what communicative goals I want learners to achieve?
- When AI interaction prioritises formal accuracy over meaningful communication, how do I notice this, and what do I do about it?
- How do I compare the quality of communicative engagement in AI-supported activities with that in teacher-led or peer interaction tasks?

5.2 I can design clearly structured language learning tasks with the help of AI

Descriptor: *To what extent do the tasks I design with AI support have clear learning goals, defined communicative outcomes and transparent evaluation criteria?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- How do I ensure that the outcomes of AI-supported communicative tasks are defined broadly enough to allow for genuine language use, rather than channelling learners towards a single expected response?
- When designing AI-supported tasks, can I co-create prompts with learners to draw on their interests, experiences and linguistic repertoires?
- When an AI-supported communicative task does not produce the learning outcomes I intended, what does my process for reviewing and revising the task look like?

5.3 I can personalise language learning experiences through the use of AI

Descriptor: *How successfully can I use AI tools to personalise learning?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Which elements of my teaching (e.g., goals, content, tasks, feedback) am I currently differentiating with AI?
- How might I use speech-to-text, text-to-speech or other assistive AI functions to support learners with specific needs without singling them out?
- How do I evaluate whether AI-assisted differentiation is actually improving learning outcomes for the learners it is intended to support, rather than simply generating more varied materials?

5.4 I can use AI to help provide feedback in responsible ways

Descriptor: *How transparent and effective is the way I integrate AI into feedback processes?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- When I use AI to generate feedback for learners, how do I communicate to them that AI has been involved?
- When AI feedback and my own professional judgment diverge, how do I handle that divergence transparently with learners?
- How do I know whether AI-assisted feedback is actually improving learner performance and self-regulation over time, rather than simply providing more feedback more quickly?